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Virginia Board of Education, Special Committee on Standards of Accreditation, Wednesday, September 16, 2020

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- Official meeting video (VDOE, YouTube): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8FApFeZ-_Z0
- Board of Education meetings, agendas and minutes (VDOE): https://www.doe.virginia.gov/state-board-data-funding/virginia-board-of-education

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Speech-to-text: whisper.cpp, model large-v3-turbo. Produced 2026-10-24. Each paragraph starts with its time [HH:MM:SS] in the meeting video.

[00:00:00] Julie how about that yes better okay I think it's already integrated in the deck then rather than switching back and forth it might be easier Emily if you don't mind just advancing the slide that's not a problem just remember to to tell me next slide Emily just so you know I'm gonna start then Julie will do the approved accountability system and then I'll wrap up with what we submitted and

[00:00:34] was rejected okay um and just so everybody knows we are live on youtube um and once we have everybody we'll get started but not until two o'clock i will go ahead and share my screen just so folks that are on the live stream know that we are starting at two and then we'll pull it down

[00:01:13] once we have everybody joined just for folks that are joining um we do we are live streaming on you two. We're waiting for all of our committee members and panelists to join the meeting and then once we have everybody I'll turn it over to Dr. Pexton to kick us off, but we are live streaming

[00:01:43] just so everyone's aware. Good afternoon Principal Conger, thank you for joining us. I think she's

[00:03:00] trying to work on getting herself unmuted. I understand that problem. Yeah, sorry I had - I had too many screens open, so I apologize. - Oh, that's no problem. Dr. Carter.

[00:03:16] - It was behind like four layers of things, so I apologize. - We understand. Dr. Carter, thank you for joining us. - Thank you for the invitation. I appreciate it. - Just to let everybody know, we are streaming live. We're not quite ready to get started yet, but we have started the live stream.

[00:03:35] So we will get started here in just a couple minutes once we have everybody joined. and i'll turn it over to dr pexton once we're ready dr hutchings thank you for joining us

[00:03:47] thank you for having me good to see everybody see that president gecker has joined dr lane has

[00:04:35] joined just waiting on a few others before we get started dr mann has joined us dr wilson can you

[00:05:24] hear us and can you hear me yes ma'am we can thank you and dr duran can you hear us yes all right Great. We'll give folks just another minute to hop on, and then I'll turn it over to Dr. Pexton.

[00:05:59] Mrs. Davis-Vaught, can you hear us? All right. Dr. Pexton, if you are ready, I will stop sharing my

[00:06:49] screen so that we can all see each other, and I will turn it over to you. Okay. Good afternoon, everyone uh appreciate you joining us uh for our next uh committee meeting uh regarding the review of the standards of accreditation again i am dr pexton and looking forward to our presentations today just a little housekeeping i know we'll have a couple of folks or at least one additional board member i believe miss holton might join us a couple minutes late i also know i want to

[00:07:28] recognize that Dr. Duran does have another obligation around 3:15, so he will be jumping off. But for everyone else who's joined us, I want to thank you for doing so. So we met a few weeks ago and received a presentation from the VDOE staff on the 2017 SOA revisions, a review of the state accreditation data trends, and an update on school quality actions and technical assistance.

[00:07:55] we also heard from the education commission of the states who provided an overview of the state accountability systems across the country i know i found that information in those presentations very helpful and i look forward to having the same experience today uh which today's meeting will feature a presentation from video vdoe staff comparing the federal accountability system with virginia accountability accreditation system and additionally we're extremely delighted uh to be joined by several superintendents and principals who will share with us their views on the positive,

[00:08:31] negative, and unintended consequences of the 2017 SOA revisions from their experience and perspectives. I will also note that the committee intends to invite additional stakeholders to our October and potentially November meetings to ensure that we receive a diverse set of views and feedback so before we dive into the presentations i will ask if the committee members have had a chance to review the minutes from the august 27 2020 committee meeting see some initial

[00:09:09] nods all right so can i get a motion to approve or amend the minutes no i'll take the motion from uh miss davis bought and i heard a second from dr duran okay thank you and if i could do a quick roll call for committee committee members uh miss davis vaught aye dr dron aye dr wilson aye great right so that motion passes um so for our first presentation today we are joined by shelley

[00:09:44] lovingrider assistant superintendent for student assessment accountability and esea programs and julie malik director of accountability if possible we will ask the committee members to hold their questions until the end of the presentation and i will turn this over to shelley to begin the discussion on the comparison of the federal accountability system requirements under essa and the virginia schools accreditation system thank you dr paxton um i am joined by my cat

[00:10:18] einstein this afternoon so i'm hopeful that he will stay on the floor but if you do see a gray tail go by that would be Einstein so I guess we all have to be mindful of the our housemates that were joined by in the virtual environment. This afternoon Julie and I are going to give you a bit of an overview of the requirements of federal accountability under ESSA and Emily if you could

[00:10:48] go to the next slide. And then Julie is going to talk with you a bit about how our currently approved plan meets the requirements of ESSA. And then she's also going to talk with you about how we identify schools for improvement under ESSA. Then I'm going to talk with you a bit about the submission that we provided initially to USDD that was rejected. Last month you received from us a two-page document

[00:11:27] that described the Virginia's plan under ESSA and the Virginia's accreditation plan and the difference. So what we wanted to do today was provide more detail about that and provide some information about the plan we attempted to submit that was rejected and then of course we'll take questions at the end so i'll turn it over to julie nan to talk a bit about the requirements

[00:11:57] under essa and are currently approved okay thank you shelley um just as a review there are three primary assessment and data requirements under s um i think we know these fairly at least the first two fairly well that we need to assess reading and mathematics annually in grades three through eight and once in high school and we also need to assess science within grade bands once in three five once in grades six nine and once in grades ten twelve and we also need to be able to disaggregate the indicators for student groups this will become critical as review the as we review the

[00:12:37] federal accountability designations in just a minute next slide please so in addition to the assessment and data requirements every state must assign indicators to measure academic achievement academic progress graduation rate progress of english learners toward english language attainment and a measure of school quality we'll talk about the use of these indicators for federal accountability in a moment but it is important to note that essa does require that the first four academic indicators carry a heavy weight in the accountability system than that of the school

[00:13:13] quality indicator you heard a little bit about this last month in the ecs presentation so i will not dwell on it. Next slide please. So these are the indicators Virginia uses to meet those criteria.

[00:13:29] This is the table found in the document provided for the August meeting. Please note that Virginia has also adopted to include an additional school quality and student success indicator of the school's accreditation rating. Unfortunately that was not part of your handout but it is one of the school quality and student success indicators so we apologize for that. The addition of this indicator allows clearly for a clear alignment to the Virginia accreditation model. I apologize that shared office space. In addition to determining the various indicators, an important piece of

[00:14:07] the ESSA plan is to assign long-term goals and measures of interim progress toward these goals to be applicable indicators. So once we have our indicators, we then set goals for those indicators. so we'll

review some of those on the next slide. Next slide, please. Okay, so this is an example of our long-term goals and measures of interim progress for reading. First thing I want to point out is if you look at the ultimate long-term goal in the last column, this aligns to level

[00:14:44] one benchmarks established for the accreditation rating. This is true for all the indicators where this applies. There is a long-term goal measure and yearly measures of interim progress for each student group a school may have so there are goals for the entire school which is the all students row and for each of the student groups the school may have the baseline is established and the baseline is established based on the 20th percentile of the achievement of the group at that time at the time the baseline was established the interim targets then connect the baseline to the

[00:15:23] long-term goal in equal increments to ensure the trajectory reaches and meets the ultimate goal. As you know, ESSA allows for revisions of these goals through amendments. Often revisions take place for a variety of reasons, but most recently these goals were adjusted for the new mathematics assessment. Next slide, please. Okay, now that we know our indicators, we know our goals, the ESSA requires that states use these indicators through a defined methodology to assign schools

[00:16:01] into various categories for improvement those categories are comprehensive support and improvement targeted support and improvement and additional targets targeted support and improvement it is also important to note that all not all schools receive a federal accountability rating in fact most schools in virginia do not have a federal designation so you either have one of these or you do not have a federal designation next slide please so this is a high overview of the required

[00:16:34] federal accountability designations oh can we go back one and requirements set forth in essa each state is then tasked with determining the methods for these identifications virginia has a multi-step process for the comprehensive support and improvement and the targeted support and improvement that we'll review in just a moment so let's first take a look at comprehensive support and improvement schools otherwise known as CSI so CSI focuses on

[00:17:06] the whole school or the all students group within a school every state is required to identify at least the lowest five percent of title one schools for this designation using all the indicators of student achievement and quality that we just discussed an additional way a school becomes of CSI schools if they have a federal graduation index rate below 67 percent this is a requirement through ESSA so let's look at targeted support and improvement targeted support and improvement

[00:17:42] focuses on consistently underperforming student groups rather than the whole school so the target support and improvement both varieties focus on the student groups title one status is not considered and the student groups within the school undergo a similar multi-step process for identification that we'll review for the CSI schools. Additional targeted support and improvement schools are also based on student groups and this category actually provides an interesting link to the other two categories. The additional targeted support schools are a subset of targeted support and

[00:18:19] improvement identified schools. Schools receive this designation if the student group in question performs lower than the highest CSI school in every indicator. So the CSI schools are identified We look at each indicator and we identify the highest performing school of each indicator.

[00:18:44] And then for the additional targeted support improvement, we look at each student group. And if they hit below that highest value for each indicator, then they receive this designation. So that's a

general overview of the three designations.

[00:19:03] Now let's look at that multi-step process that I mentioned a couple times for CSI and targeted support. Thank you, Emily. So this is a multi-step process used to identify CSI schools. Again, the target of support and improvement schools follow a very similar process, just looking at student groups.

[00:19:22] So the first step in this process considers the academic achievement and graduation indicators required under ESSA. First and foremost, schools must meet those measures of interim progress, which we looked at earlier. If a school does not meet this criteria, they move to the next step, which involves growth.

[00:19:42] If they do not meet this criteria, they're evaluated against EL progress if it applies to that school. And then finally, the process considers that the school met the school quality and student success indicators, including accreditation. If they do not meet any of these criteria and are in the lowest 5% of Title I schools for CSI, they receive this designation.

[00:20:04] like i said it's a similar process for student groups so they have to pass all the all the steps or not pass all the steps in this case and then they receive the designation so that's an overview of the current the current process the current flow and the current methodology i'm going to pass it over to shelley to talk about some historical concepts that led us to this point shelley thank you julie so that is our approved

[00:20:40] plan, but it is not the one that we first submitted. If we think back a couple of years ago, ESSA was signed into law in December of 2015, so we were attempting to develop our federal accountability plan under ESSA around the same time that we were revising the standards of accreditation and so our hope was that we could align the two systems very closely for those of

[00:21:14] you who've been in education in virginia for a while you will remember that the previous law no child left behind was very prescriptive and its requirements for the identification of schools for improvement left very little latitude for states and so we ended up with the situation where we often had schools that might be fully accredited under our state system but they were identified for federal improvement and under no child left behind so when uh every student succeeds act was

[00:21:52] signed into law um those of us in virginia were very excited because it sounded like we would have much more flexibility under this new law and the hope was that we could more closely align our state system to the federal system. And there was even talk that perhaps we could move to a situation where we would have only one system. There are some things about ESSA requirements that do not fit well with the state accreditation system and I'll go over those in a minute. So eventually we

[00:22:32] we decided that we would try to align the two systems as closely as possible, continuing to use those aspects of the Virginia system that we value, but that are not allowed under the federal requirements in state accreditation.

[00:22:52] So again, we were trying to align as closely as possible with the ultimate goal that we would have consistency in schools that were identified for improvement under ASTOM and those that were identified as needing corrective action under our state accreditation system.

[00:23:13] In other words, those that had an indicator at level three or red. Next slide, please, Emily. So the next few slides really deal with those known conflicts.

[00:23:30] so we knew that federal accountability under ESSA requires that we use the federal graduation indicator or the federal graduation rate and those particular requirements are such that we can only use the standard or the advanced studies diploma we cannot use the special diploma or the applied studies diploma as it's now called and we also cannot give credit for students who exit with

[00:24:03] a certificate of completion or um day in uh this in the virginia public schools as you all will remember from our discussion of the accreditation system what we use in accreditation is the graduation and completion index where students are given varying points depending on their exiting credentials so more points for a diploma but we also give a smaller number of points for students who exit with a certificate or those

[00:24:36] who stay in school past the usual four years so as we were developing the two systems we knew that this was an area where we would have to have some depth next slide emily we also knew that we had so we would have some required differences in the assessments that are used in virginia we use all of the sol tests for example for mathematics we use all of our end of course tests for high

[00:25:12] schools that would be algebra one algebra two and geometry we also use the virginia alternate assessment which is given to students with significant cognitive disabilities and then I think most of you are aware that we also have a very large number of board-approved substitute tests. So these would be tests like advanced placement, IB, SAT, ACT tests that students might take that could be used as a substitute for the SOL test. So all of those tests are used

[00:25:49] in our state accreditation system but under ESSA we are only allowed to use one end of course test per subject area so for mathematics we chose algebra one which means that except under special circumstances we cannot use geometry or algebra two scores for science we chose biology because that is the the test that the largest number of Virginia students take and we cannot include earth

[00:26:24] science or chemistry scores and of course for reading we include included the end of course reading test so the the real differences in the test are that we have a larger number of tests that are eligible for inclusion and accreditation in Virginia and then we are allowed under ASSA and And that includes the varying end of course tests for mathematics and science, and also the larger number of substitute tests that are used in accreditation.

[00:26:58] So we accounted for these known differences as we were developing the two systems. Next slide, Emily. and next one too but we did want to try to submit as much of our accreditation system or our state system as we could and you'll remember from julie's explanation that essa requires long-term goals and interim measures of progress for each of these indicators did an

[00:27:36] achievement growth for elementary and middle schools and progress of english learners towards attainment in English proficiency. Our initial submission used the combined rate to address the requirements for these indicators. So instead of separating these as we are currently required, we use the combined rate as we do with accreditation so that a school would get credit,

[00:28:09] I'll use reading for an example, for a student who passed the test. They would also get credit for a student who failed the SOL reading test, but made progress. And then in addition for English learners, we also gave the school credit for students who neither passed the SOL reading test nor made growth on the SOL reading test, but they did make progress in learning English as measured

[00:28:44] by the access for ELLS test. And our rationale in doing this was that when you think about the ultimate goal of ESSA is to identify schools that need the most help, the most assistance.

[00:29:03] And so if you think about what the combined rate really tells us, if we have a school where students are not passing the reading test, they're not showing growth on the reading test, and if they're English learners, they're perhaps not showing progress towards learning English, then that really does identify a school that needs the most assistance. And so that's why those of us at the department who were working on these plans felt really strongly that particularly for the

[00:29:42] identification of schools that need the most help that the combined rate provided the most accurate indication of a school that perhaps was struggling so you'll see here in red that we did use the combined rate and you'll also notice that there's a watermark behind this that says outdated information we don't want anyone to think that this is what we're doing currently it is what we submitted initially and then we submitted the federal graduation indicator as required and then

[00:30:18] as julie mentioned our school quality indicator in that first submission was just chronic absenteeism next slide emily this just reiterates why we thought the combined rate was really important that that really is again outdated information so our methodology here was to identify schools we again were ranking schools and based on the combined rate and selecting those that were in

[00:30:51] the bottom five percent. USED did reject this plan and the primary reason was the combined rate. USED's interpretation of the ESSA law was that this was not allowed and that we had to provide separate indicators which is what is reflected in the plan that Julie talked about. We are very pleased that we are able to continue to use the combined rate in the Virginia system. I think department staff feel that it does provide credit for what Virginians value in terms of moving

[00:31:31] students towards proficiency and does um do a good job of identifying uh schools that might really need additional assistance and dr pexton if there's time julie and i would be happy to answer any questions thank you miss levy writer and also miss malik for that overview of the of the information um i would like to allow at least the next five or ten minutes for any kind of q a uh so that we can leave a sufficient amount of time for our panel discussion. So I will open the floor up

[00:32:08] to committee members and others to see if there's any questions. Dr. Paxton, I don't have any questions. I just want to thank both Julie and Shelley for doing a great job presenting the information. As someone who works in the field, it's information I knew, but I think the way you presented it today for the public and those that are listening was very clear. So I just want to thank you for that clarity, particularly the part that you provided in terms of why it was rejected and the rationale that went into that. I don't think that's something that everyone has

[00:32:43] heard of, you know, at least as a larger community, haven't heard that. I think the smaller educational communities, some that are really attuned to that have, but part of our discussion and part of our role here as this committee, I think is important to provide all that clarity and background information. And so I think, I just want to thank you for doing that so well today, and I appreciate working with both of you very welcome thank you dr pexton i have a comment and a question yes thank you uh also to shelley and julie really helpful um i like hearing the history because

[00:33:17] sometimes i do think we forget um i have a question that is um comes to mind the as i look at slide six which is the examples of long-term goal and interim measures of progress this brings the

question to mind but i don't know dr pexton that this is really the purview of this committee or this meeting but thinking about the fact that we have outlined targets for several years toward

[00:33:46] this long-term goal for 24 25 and knowing that progress um has been in perhaps interrupted for a number of our students across the commonwealth with regard to covid spring term and now as we we find ourselves in a different modality, delivery modality and learning modality in the fall.

[00:34:08] We don't know how long that's going to last, but wondering on the ESSA side, if there's any statement or expectation that we have been provided to either adjust or talk through what we anticipate our progress might be, if it's too early to tell, or if we expect that that could be something we will be asked to reflect on I think from an accreditation perspective we all of us are likely thinking about the impact of covid as we think about progress of our students across the across

[00:34:46] the state so dr wilson um I think you all are aware that for the current school year um for 19 20 we i'm sorry 2021 we do not have to identify uh schools for improvement under the federal law at this point uh the assessments for the spring 21 have not been waived and so that means that potentially we will have to identify schools for the 21-22 school year under federal law you all

[00:35:26] are aware that accreditation has already been waived for 21-22 the long-term targets you saw for reading we typically would have requested an amendment this year because as you all will recall we would have administered new reading tests in spring of 20 at schools not been closed so there will be an opportunity once those new tests are administered and hopefully in spring of 21

[00:35:58] to adjust our targets and submit that as an amendment to uscd so there will be an opportunity to adjust through the amendment process does that help it does i just think it i wanted to just make the point that while we have targets there's a process for either relaxation or waiver or whatever it is and not every thing is in lockstep meaning ESSA and or accreditation at the state

[00:36:34] level and you know all of those pieces while they speak to each other may not necessarily be completely aligned in terms of timing and so just keeping in mind that um that we are still in process frankly thank you shelly hey any other questions for shelley or julie or any other

[00:37:06] comments okay great really appreciate that that overview and that presentation and for opposite of dr duran for someone who's very distant from it um and getting that baseline overview was very helpful for me all right so now we will transition to the second part of our agenda today which is a panel discussion with virginia's superintendents and principals on the positive negative and unintended consequences of the 2017 revision for the soa um if as a committee we recall this was

[00:37:45] one of our primary or i won't say primary one of our uh key tasks that we really wanted to unpack and better understand knowing that it has not been that long since 2017 we really wanted some some empathy data some some real world feedback from our presidents and i'm sorry principals and superintendents um and so looking forward to this discussion uh just a couple of logistics uh so just in full transparency i i have a hard stop at 355. i've got a present on another panel at four. And so I have over-engineered this process with my shipyard background and so I'm

[00:38:24] going to be really structured around the times that we allocate for each one of the questions. And so I'll help kind of moderate this. What we'll do is we have, we've Emily provided our panelists with five questions to answer and I'll review those questions in a second. I'm going to break those questions down a little bit, ask our participants to offer their thoughts relative to those questions within a certain

amount of time frame and once we go through the questions i've built in a little bit of time at the end that if for some reason i've got to you know cut you off to move on to the next or you don't get a chance to express uh your your response at the end everybody will have a go back and get a chance to kind of wrap up their final thoughts and add

[00:39:04] any other thoughts that we didn't get to cover um so just uh just so you know obviously we are going to be talking about the positive negative and unintended consequences but two additional questions that we'll be posing after that discussion is what policies and practices have you changed or put in place as a result of the new SOA and at the same time have any initiatives been put in place to support chronic absenteeism so that'll be kind of one question I'll pose later on I'm in the last question I'll pose will be how has your support of economically

[00:39:38] disadvantaged or English learner students changed as a result of the new SOA so just kind of want to tee up the whole audience with what the primary questions will be for this discussion. For our panel today, we're pleased to be joined by Dr. Dennis Carter, who is the superintendent of Smith County Public Schools. Dr. Carter is a lifelong educator in Smith County Public Schools. He began his career as a special education instructional assistant and has held various educator roles, including special education teacher, assistant principal, and assistant superintendent.

[00:40:17] he was also selected as superintendent in smith county in 2017. i'm assuming that meant to be maybe superintendent of the year either way it was a recognizable honor uh miss casey conger or conjure i apologize for which one i got it wrong and hopefully i got one of them right principal at the wt cook elementary schools in virginia beach she has previously served as the tidewater zone director for the virginia association of elementary school principals and is currently serving as president-elect. She also serves on the board of Virginia Beach Education Foundation and the

[00:40:55] Virginia Beach Association of Elementary Principals and has recently served on the VDOE Return to School Task Force. Ms. Maria Eck, principal at Justice High School in Fairfax, was selected as principal of Justice High School in July of 2018. She previously served as principal of Edgar Allan Poe Middle School and McNair Elementary School. And prior to joining Fairfax County Public Schools, she worked in Miami-Dade County Public Schools as an administrator, classroom teacher, and ESOL

[00:41:28] teacher. We have Dr. Greg Hutchings, superintendent of Alexandria City Public Schools. He's an experienced educator and administrator and has served as a teacher, assistant principal, and principal at the middle and high school levels and director of pre-k through 12 initiatives for Alexandria City Public Schools. He began his teaching career in Manassas at Prince William County Public Schools and has worked in Chesterfield County Public Schools. And our last panelist is Dr. Scott Kisner, Superintendent of Stafford County Public Schools. Dr. Kisner has

[00:42:07] more than 20 years of experience as a school superintendent. He served for eight years as a superintendent of Harrison City Public Schools in Harrisonburg, I'm sorry, Harrisonburg City public schools in Harrisonburg, Virginia. Prior to becoming a superintendent, his educational experiences include teaching children with disabilities, being a school psychologist, directing special education programs, and serving as an assistant superintendent of instruction in the northern Shenandoah region of Virginia. So we know just based on this wealth of background and experience that the insights from this group will offer, this insight this group will offer

[00:42:43] will be valuable to the committee as we continue our review of the SOA. So to kick things off, we will begin the discussion with the first three primary questions. What have been the positive, negative, and unintended consequences of the SOA from your perspectives?

[00:43:03] I will ask each panelist to provide a response within about four to five minutes each for your response. And I will ask, and rather than, I guess, well, everybody's here to speak, So I guess I will do some ball and tolling and just kind of maybe ask Dr. Carter if you will start off for us.

[00:43:25] Sure. Thank you. And I appreciate the opportunity to be here with you today. Positives with the 2017 Standards of Accreditation, it's a great start. It's a good movement with the look of accountability in the Commonwealth. And I believe that as educators, we all believe in evaluation and accountability.

[00:43:42] The evaluation piece clearly we use every day through formative assessments as educators and really build our educational practices around the deficits that we identify with our students. So again, to state clearly, I do support evaluation accountability and I think we all do as educators.

[00:44:02] The transition of the looks, the goods of the Standards of Accreditation 2017, the flexibility, the additional flexibility, the examination of alternative assessments or authentic assessments, performance assessments, is a good starting point in looking at those components are certainly a move in the right direction.

[00:44:26] Additionally, looking at the growth model, being able to identify the SOL scores and seeing growth within our youngsters and schools receiving credit for that. You know, it's hard as a school system to really wrap your mind around being held accountable based on one day's worth of testing or a retake in that regard.

[00:44:46] But being able to look at students and being able to see growth within that youngster is certainly a benefit for the student, for the teacher, for the school and for the community. When we look at the unintended consequences or the negatives, I suppose, when you look at the negatives, I've got to target just for a minute the chronic absenteeism piece.

[00:45:07] And you'll hear me speak about chronic absenteeism later on because I do think that we have worked to implement, as many school divisions around the Commonwealth have done, to implement strategies and procedures to help with chronic absenteeism. but there are some barriers that we face that are difficult to navigate when you're when you're looking at chronic absenteeism as an indicator for a school success or a school division success and some of those indicators you know as a school division we have focused strongly on building foundational relationships with our students working to be a trauma-informed community and

[00:45:43] building resilience with our kids um working with families to try to try to show the importance of education i'll speak about this this later but there there are those groups that are difficult to reach and and it's difficult to get those youngsters to come to school for various reasons and and additionally another compounding factor is our court systems now they handle truancy and i'm just speaking throughout region seven we have 19 school divisions within region seven and when you're looking at the legal system and that that piece with truancy we do have some courts

[00:46:19] that handle that differently and understandably so and certainly um judges have the right to handle it differently but it does make it a bit challenging for uh for enforcing the truancy piece so so the good flexibility great the uh looking at the additional components for um looking at growth fantastic uh

the bad there are some unintended consequences lumping those with the bad of some things that are out of our control and being able to handle those and again i think it has made us much stronger. I think it has helped solidify our stance as public educators

[00:46:54] on the importance of relationships and building that bridge to families and striving to show the importance of coming in for an education. So to sum up, a great start. We do encourage continued conversation as you're having now about the movement of accreditation and accountability.

[00:47:14] of Virginia. Thank you. Keisha, you're on mute. I'll start over. Thank you, Dr. Carter, for your comments. And I was asking Ms. Conjure if I was saying her name correctly. You said it right the first time, Conger, but it's okay. I'll answer to anything at this point. Okay, great. Would you mind offering your thoughts about the positive, negative, and unintended consequences of the SOAs?

[00:47:45] Absolutely. Thank you so much for letting me be a part of this. I hope you don't mind. I prepared some comments, so I hope you'll forgive me reading it, but I knew the time was going to be really tight and i wanted to make sure that i got in the point so um as she said earlier i am an elementary principal so my hope was to we know the soa revisions affect whole districts but my hope was to just bring some insight on actual impacts at the elementary level and provide some specifics i know sometimes we can talk overarching so i tried to pick out some specific things that actually impact my school here in Virginia Beach. In the past accreditation was focused mostly upon

[00:48:25] state SLL testing. Often there were students who made significant progress toward these standards. However, many of these students still fell behind the mandated benchmarks. For example, a fourth grader reading on a first grade level might have grown to a third grade reading level but would have not passed the fourth grade reading assessments. The revisions identified a variety of indicators which provide a more well-rounded measure and more of a timeline of success rather than a snapshot of a single point of time test with the 2017 revisions growth from year to year is now considered the progress of our english language learners towards english acquisition is

[00:49:01] now taken into consideration and the focus is on continued improvement and progress and in my particular school we have a very high population of english language learners i have over 100 students in my 500 student school who are english language learners so showing their progress toward english acquisition is a huge plus for us these changes are particularly important as well for our students with disabilities as schools are now able to acknowledge and celebrate growth for students who have historically struggled on these assessments across the commonwealth outcomes for schools are so much greater than overall sol scores however accountability is

[00:49:39] necessary and something we must keep in mind the soa revisions allow schools to celebrate success on multiple criteria while keeping the focus on continuous improvement closing gaps within our student populations as well as addressing chronic absenteeism although the overall changes to the soa are more positive than anything there are a few notable outcomes that i feel at the elementary level while the overall number of sol tests decreased which is a definite plus there was no funding that followed the mandate to assess students with local alternative assessments in content grade three science grade five writing sixth and seventh grade history so that was a

[00:50:18] mandate and no funding followed that it's also notable that schools in level two for more than four consecutive years they moved to level three because all indicators were not met on to level one regardless of improvement this is concerning for example relative to chronic absenteeism as an indicator

of school performance while no one is arguing the fact that students need to be in class in order to receive appropriate instruction attendance is especially challenging for some schools and in some areas my school for example is at the virginia beach oceanfront we sit on 15th street in mediterranean two blocks from the beach after labor day when the motel rates

[00:50:57] drop we have a huge influx of students who are homeless who move into the motels and move from motel to motel weekly while we work to meet their needs with special programs extended hours and individual attendance plans with each family that i'll talk about later their very inconsistent housing situations bring about chronic attendance concerns every time they move rooms or places they miss school for that day we have a very high mobility rate at cook at one time we were 53 transient meaning our school was 53 different at the end of the year than what we started at

[00:51:32] that has decreased a little bit over time the fact of the matter is our students cannot get themselves to school nor do they have control over their family's day-to-day schedule or lifestyle we know that daily attendance is distinctly tied to environmental circumstances which are often out of our control this will continuously be a focus for us and one of great importance however knowing that one accreditation standard is based upon this brings about a certain level of anxiety one other unintended consequence of the adjustments is that tests that are taken solely for federal accountability are counted in accreditation calculations as well for students

[00:52:09] who do not need to test for graduation but need to participate due to federal requirements performance could be affected and worth noting conversely students who do not need to take the test for purposes of verified credits and who do not take it are still counted as non-participants which can impact the expected participation rate this was the case here in virginia beach last year it's also important to note that many of our students are counted in multiple gap groups we have students with disabilities who are economically disadvantaged and who are english language learners which could put their performance in several gap groups simultaneously having impact

[00:52:41] on those specific gap groups thank you great thank you for those those comments miss conger all right mrs eck i would love to hear your response relative to the positive negative and unintended consequences of the soa okay thank you let me just i've got two cursors going and so please forgive me uh let me just come in here and talk to you guys a little bit thank you for having me and letting me um and giving me this opportunity to speak to you about the standards of accreditation and in particular the effect on how the dropout rate is currently calculated on

[00:53:21] our school um i am the principal of justice high school in fairfax county and justice high school has the largest english learner population in fcps just to give you a little brief as of monday on September 14th, we had 835 English language learners in our school out of the 2,300 students.

[00:53:42] To break it down even further, that's 36% of our school population, and of those students, 273 were ESOL level 1s, 187 were ESOL level 2s, 308 were level 3s, and 66 were level 4s. For our class of 2020 so our most recent graduating class 130 of our 505 graduates were english learners levels one through four so as you can imagine the soa has an impact in our school tremendously

[00:54:16] as we particular and we particularly appreciate that the impact of late enrolling english learners on our school accreditation is among the areas of your focus today just to tell you some of the positives and i'm trying to look at the camera but the tv's on the other side of the room is some of the things that we've done is we have changed our esol programming right because of the soa so really laser

focus on our students so that english learners are sitting in classes that count towards graduation requirements beginning ninth grade we've hired two esol counselors who support

[00:54:51] the emotional needs of our students many who are homeless working jobs late at night and getting up the next morning to come to school we hired an on-time graduation specialist three deans of student one additional assistant principal one additional instructional coach and purchased an additional social worker and all of these additional positions are funded by school fund these staff members work to prevent students from dropping out of school due to the perceived barriers such as needing child care completing paperwork required for new student registration or finding transportation to and from school and work. In addition, these staff members work to

[00:55:29] locate and encourage re-enrollment of students who have already dropped out. For example, our on-time graduation specialists will follow a student for years, years well after they've left Justice. They reach out to the students throughout different times of the school year to continue to offer multiple pathways to high school diploma. Our staff has also taken a collective approach, a collective responsibility right that includes all teachers administrators other key staff as school psychologists our systems of support advisor instructional coaches and parent liaisons so like at the beginning of the year we put out a list of our thing of our students who are on time

[00:56:08] graduation uh concerns and we start to reach out to our teachers for mentoring uh for to find our students to see what we can do to locate if we haven't located the student um a little bit let tell you about our class of 2020 right of of the students who graduated 505 of them 204 were second language students so they roughly comprised 40 percent of our graduates and of these eight were esau level one 29 were level two's 75 were level threes 18 were level fours and 74 successfully

[00:56:42] completed uh the english for speakers for other languages program so up 80 and 86 of those 505 graduates arrived in the united states in 2015 or later so at justice we believe that high school graduation is the stepping stone to a better future for students and so when we say all we mean all means all in the last few years we have made some noteworthy progress at justice and we've closed a lot of academic uh and non-academic indicators and so in 2016 our graduation and

[00:57:19] completion index was 83 83 and today our gci is 87.85 so we've reduced our dropout rate from 16.1 percent in 2016 to 11.85 in 2020. um some of the i don't want to say negatives but some of the never in order for us i want to show you a bigger picture of who dropped out of justice in the 2020 cohort right so we had 69 students uh who were in our cohort of dropouts in 2020.

[00:57:53] 32 attended justice for more than four semesters nine of those students were considered students with limited or interrupted formal education as reported by the student or parent and 28 of them were new to the country and justice was their first u.s school for 32 for the these 32 students although the circumstances of entering high school as their first experience in u.s schools as new immigrants is unique compared to their peers at other schools the fact that they have started high school in a standard progression as a 14 or 15 year old ninth grader and that we have

[00:58:32] had them for more than two years places these students within the norm of what other high schools face when confronting the problem of lowering the dropout rate the remaining 37 students among these 69s attended justice less than four semesters most of these students were 17 at the time of enrollment and were initially placed in ninth grade meaning that they were placed in a four-year cohort in

which they would be 21 or older by the time they graduated while their peers would be 17 or 18. these 37 students are dropping out as adults after less than two years in a high

[00:59:06] school while the circumstances for each student is unique these students are often what they have in common is that they live they're living in the u.s on their own and drop out due to life commitments that come with adulthood and the demands of financial independence they drop out before reaching their senior year so the soa however measures these adult students who have been with us for less than four semesters the same way we would measure these students who have been in school since kindergarten or even compared to kids who enter high school at the normal age of 14 and 15 years old and have been at our students for more than two years these group of adult students

[00:59:46] drop out with less than two years of u.s high school despite our best efforts to retain them adult responsibility takes over takes priority so by holding schools to the same standard of accreditation best based on academic standards it's equitable holding schools to those same standards for dropouts is inequitable because the soa does not consider the age of the students entering the school the length of u.s schooling the time in school the language level and the age appropriateness of placement and previous education and so if i can also add um that despite our best

[01:00:23] efforts to meet and exceed the soas and academics and our um and all our improvements in the dropout rates the result of this generic way that the soa views dropouts places our school in accreditation with conditions category and this status continues to have a negative effect on the morale of our teachers students and community and it inadvertently undermines our efforts to improve the instructional practices in reaching our students so we are committed to taking responsibility for our dropout rate as it is faced by other schools in the state however we do believe that those

[01:00:58] students who have been with us for less than four semesters and who have dropped out as adults are are appropriately counted in the dropout metric used to meet the threshold set by VDOE. We urge you to consider these changes in your calculation methodologies to more appropriately account for these unique circumstances.

[01:01:17] So thank you for inviting me to participate and focusing on English learners as part of your review. - Great, thank you, Ms. Eck. We're doing great on time. Ready to hear from Dr. Hutchins. Would love to hear your feedback.

[01:01:34] - So one, let me just say thank you all for the opportunity to be able to speak today. And I do wanna commend the Virginia Board of Education just for the simple fact that we are tackling this. I mean, I think this is the first steps of us trying to tackle some of the inequities in public education.

[01:01:53] I still think we have some room to grow and I'll talk a little bit about that, but I think that this is definitely a step in the right direction. One thing I do wanna say in regards to positives is that the addition of calculating the growth measures in the accreditation ratings, it finally gave schools credit for improving their student performance in ways that weren't captured previously.

[01:02:13] So for example, our English learners, our students with disabilities, those students who are challenged with socioeconomic backgrounds, that it allowed us to really give credit to those schools as well as the students who have made tremendous academic progress, but may not have necessarily passed the SOL.

[01:02:33] And I think that that is something that is commendable because historically we have not really given the credit to the schools. And I believe in some ways it was a disservice to students because they did work hard and they made the progress but they wouldn't get the recognition for showing credit.

[01:02:50] They made them feel as if they were failures. And I think a lot of our staff as well as principals have said that in the past about the former accreditation guidelines. We also saw that the addition to the standards of accreditation that taking the subgroups into account and subgroup performance into account.

[01:03:09] It helped tremendously because now it is also allowing us to not just focus on the all student group, but really honing in on each of our subgroups to ensure that every single student achieves at high levels.

[01:03:24] And I think that we've had significant inequities, not just here in ACPS, but across the Commonwealth, really across the nation. And because we were not really following the progress of each and every subgroup and being held accountable for that. Some people were able to get away with not serving every student.

[01:03:43] And I think that some people will call this a negative. I necessarily don't call this a negative and neither does Alexander City Public Schools, but the fact that some people had really high ratings with the former accreditation rating scales, that their ratings may not be as high now, that we're looking at specific subgroups.

[01:04:00] And I think that that's commendable though, that we are holding all of our school divisions accountable. I have to say that once the 2017 Standards of Accreditation were adopted for the first time in 20 years, in 2019, ACPS, we had all of our schools accredited, the first time in 20 years.

[01:04:20] So I say that, you know, that was a wonderful thing in celebration for us because we know that our staff and has been working extremely hard, but we were not getting that kind of recognition. But I do believe many school divisions may call that a negative because their schools may not be accredited any longer because all of the subgroups were not being held accountable.

[01:04:41] I also think some of the unintended consequences that come from, you know, any time you're doing as you are, any time you're introducing new standards, there's always gonna be some type of unintended consequence. One that I think is important for us to just hone on is the fact that, yes, we've made progress with trying to look at multiple ways to monitor our students' progress across the Commonwealth of Virginia.

[01:05:08] But we have also, or we're still just, in a sense, using one data point. I know we have some alternative assessments that have been added to this. But we are still technically, for the most part, using our SOL as how we determine the effectiveness of our schools and our school divisions.

[01:05:27] And I think that during this global pandemic, this is an opportunity where we are able to rethink what accountability looks like. This is an opportunity for us to really rethink what achievement looks like for our young people. And because we have had to pivot overnight to assessing kids and teaching students and having them engaged in very different ways, this is an opportunity, I believe, for the Virginia Department of Education as well as for the U.S. Department of Education to really start looking at multiple ways to monitor our students' progress and multiple ways to assess our students.

[01:06:05] Because we have such a diverse population. I know here in Alexandria, we have over 120 countries represented in our school division. And many of our students who are immigrants to this country, they have proper schooling in their countries, but they don't speak the English language. And they might be able to demonstrate mastery of the SOLs by using their specific language and being tested in their specific language.

[01:06:28] And I think we just need to start thinking through how we can be a little more diverse with assessments of our students. So thank you. - Great, thank you, Dr. Hutchins. Very informative.

[01:06:43] All right, Dr. Kisner. And one point of note before your comments, Dr. Kisner, I do just wanna let the audience know, I am gonna, after we hear from Dr. Kisner, I am gonna switch to the last question we had. So you can just kind of be preparing your thoughts, which was how has your support of economically disadvantaged or EL students changed as a result?

[01:07:06] Because I know Dr. Duran has to leave early and I also know that's very near and dear to his heart. So just wanted our panelists to be aware of that change and Dr. Kisner, looking very forward to hearing from you and your thoughts on the positive, negative and unintended consequences. - Okay, and I also wanna thank you for the opportunity.

[01:07:23] I think Dr. Hutchings comments are really speak a lot about my experience in Stafford County Public Schools. So as you already indicated, I was superintendent in Harrisonburg City and Martinsville City Public Schools, which truly have a completely different demographic profile than a school system like Stafford County Public Schools.

[01:07:47] And when I was superintendent in Martinsville and Harrisonburg, not that I'm not one that believes in competition, but I did recognize that those schools had continued to have most amazing children that any one of us could hope to work with.

[01:08:07] But often that community had additional challenges than maybe a place that I'm currently at in Stafford. And not only did they have challenges, but then when the accreditation ratings came out, it often reinforced that this school system was not meeting the needs of children, but I could tell you most adults every waking moment were trying to meet the needs of children.

[01:08:37] So the new accreditation ratings where I think to follow up with my colleague from Alexandria is talking about Stafford is a school system that I think most people will consider a high performing school division, especially if you look at it in the aggregate. So with the new accreditation metrics and the way we look at subgroups, it became quite obvious that among our 30,000 students, we had a good portion of our children not doing well, children struggling. And it shined a light

[01:09:11] on it and it began to have great conversations about equity and fairness and where we're putting our resources and do we believe in every child or we just say every child.

[01:09:27] So I think one of the most positive outcomes of the new accreditation system, as you already heard, is talking about in the subgroups less than the aggregate. And I also, along those lines, I think the other indicators that was mentioned in a presentation also helps the public better understand the profile of their school system.

[01:09:54] One of, I didn't really see a lot of negative outcomes, but one thing that I would just quickly mention, you know, when the positive was going from six ratings to three ratings, it still might be a little

confusing to the public. I think it's confusing to the educators.

[01:10:12] The new system, you know, while simplified, still has complexity, you know, such as level one at or above standard level two approaching standard and a level three below standard it's it may give um you know it may give uh people uh some difficulty understanding exactly what that means i'm just going to mention one thing of a potential negative consequence um like my other people i put a lot together but i'll respect the time so um one of the things that we notice when

[01:10:45] you have two indicators, passing rate and growth, but then you get a single score in a sense for your SOA, I think it might potentially give a false sense of how a school is actually performing when it looks at the pass rate. I think most of the public interprets that score to mean that's the percentage of children that have passed and what obviously what it also means is your growth rate

[01:11:21] although i'm very supportive of the growth rate um i don't want to lose sight of we don't want to lose sight of that there is still a a mark a benchmark that you have to meet so um stafford and i'm sure a lot of other school systems we spend a lot of time uh being very transparent with our public about the calculation of the raw pass rates. So people could understand, although our scores look pretty positive, when we break it down by individual children, individual subgroups,

[01:12:00] it's not as strong as the published report. So that's something, you know, that I recognize, we recognize and then the last thing um i still think uh um stafford and i think probably a lot of us need to still do a better job of explaining the growth model versus a proficiency model i still think um there's a lot of complexity to that um and um you know i think in order for the

[01:12:36] public to be engaged in their school system uh one of the most positive things about covet 19 if one could say something's positive about COVID-19 is the level of engagement uh families are having about their child's education so um I think if we could get to that level of um a collaboration with our community that will help build greater support but anyway thank you very good okay I'll move on to our next question um and again I will also reiterate that uh

[01:13:15] each panelist will have a time to go back, as well as I have built in time for some Q&A from our committee. So again, the next question was, how has your support of economically disadvantaged or English learner students changed as a result of the new SOA? And we'll start back with, well, for these questions here, I'm going to kind of leave these open-ended and allow those who would really like to speak to those based on your experiences to offer those thoughts so uh the floor is open um i'll check pexton dr pexton sure dr duran can we ask also

[01:13:55] as they provide that you know how has it changed in terms of the positive and what are some of the burdens and some of the changes that have occurred as a result to trying to meet uh some of the expectations that because i do think that i would love to hear that there's some positive changes but i would like to hear what the changes have been as a result to try and meet those that have have been negative and unintended.

[01:14:15] I'd love to hear both perspectives. Thank you, Dr. Bexler. - Great, I think Dr. Hutchings was going to go first. - So yeah, I was just gonna say one, I think that the new guidelines really have validated the work that we were already doing.

[01:14:31] It didn't necessarily change how we were serving our students with special needs and our English learners, but it did allow us to not feel as if our work was in vain because we had been working

hard for several years. And with the previous guidelines, it just did not afford us an opportunity to show the growth of our students.

[01:14:50] And it seemed as if we were constantly combating or trying to negate what the state was saying about us. So we were in a defensive mode with the previous guidelines. Whereas now, we're able to say, you see our students and teachers, you are rocking it.

[01:15:05] You're doing your thing. Yes, we still have room to grow, but the kids are making some growth and that's a celebration. So I think that validation piece is so important. So I don't have anything that has necessarily changed. One thing that has changed and it wasn't necessarily because of the standards of accreditation guidelines, but we now require all of our schools to have a school improvement plan.

[01:15:31] Whereas previously prior to my arrival here in Alexandria, that we just had our schools that were low performing or who were not accredited to have a school improvement plan. So now it is a standard across the board. We also have incorporated quarterly meetings where myself, the superintendent, as well as our central office support team, that we meet with our school principals and their leadership teams to talk through any barriers that they may have.

[01:15:56] And we specifically focus on our students with special needs, our English learners, as well as our just low-performing and underrepresented student populations for that particular school. And it varies depending on the school. it is definitely customized but that has been a huge benefit because it has allowed us as well as me as the superintendent to really understand are there decisions are there practices are there policies that's preventing our principals and their staff from meeting the needs of our students and that we don't have to wait to see you know our accreditation results or our SOL results that

[01:16:31] we're able every nine weeks to check in and to make those changes you know when needed so that that our students' needs are met earlier. Great. Thank you. Other thoughts?

[01:16:49] So, one thing I would maybe add, so my sense in this school system was that when we talked about economically disadvantaged children and when we talked about English language learners, we didn't really celebrate these children. We talked about it as a potential financial burden because we would have to have smaller class sizes, more staff and so on and so on.

[01:17:19] So I think one of the positives which has also created some tension in this community to be honest is the positive is that there were many great people in our school system and outside the school system that really did want to talk about the equity agenda and really want to make sure these kids are successful. But we had to restructure and I'll give you a very specific example the area that we struggle the most in the accreditation system is the middle school and our

[01:17:51] middle school model very much had a lot of resources and support for children not that i want to take things away from anyone but there was a lot of support and resources for children that were students in the algebra one and two and geometry classes, and that often drove the schedule. So in our eight middle schools about two years ago, we started a lot of professional development on a tiered intervention support system. And this year, even though school year is different,

[01:18:29] we are still fully implementing our tier level of support, which meant that some other that schedule changes had to be made, and resources had to be reallocated.

[01:18:45] But what we also did was create a division-wide, a community-wide committee on equity, opportunity, and diversity, which has about 50, 60 different stakeholders besides school staff. So I think it's actually been a healthy, it has been a healthy discussion. It has had some, you know, moments where maybe the dialogue wasn't as healthy as I would have liked it to be, but I think you need to have

[01:19:16] that to move forward. So I think the accountability system, in a sense, gave us permission. Not that I really needed permission, but it gave us permission to talk about it on how it impacts the entire community if you don't meet certain standards. Thank you, Dr. Kisner. I think I can just speak for in virginia beach i think we really they really looked at restructuring to where it became more of a year-long conversation this than just a point in time end of the year status and so

[01:19:54] um you know putting a plan for continuous improvement process in place where we meet regularly and set forth goals and are constantly looking at those and rerouting as necessary and it's more of a working document than just a plan that we set forth for the year we meet with our you know um supervisors and even our superintendent regularly and that's based on where your school is scoring depending on how many meetings that you have but it's more of a it's not just a plan that we create at the beginning of the year and then we wait to the end of the year to see what our our results are we kind of reflect and refine the entire year and put things in place as things come

[01:20:32] about one of the things that i continuously keep thinking about is we all know that i mean i think everybody probably on this call is a bit more tired this year than ever with all of the i heard dr hutchins say pivot and we have pivoted so very much right now um but the i do think that it has broken down some barriers for us and parents are now um right alongside of us and of course there are barriers that we're still continuously working but it also has taken barriers down for teachers and so um i think we can use some of those things as a positive because

[01:21:08] we have had to walk hand in hand a little bit more than ever before. One of the things that we're really focusing on as a result of these gap groups is we always talk about support for the student, but the student cannot be successful if the family is not successful. So reaching out in a bit more broad perspective, we have family outreach specialists that have been assigned to certain schools for certain areas of support, and particularly we have students that need support, but the family needs support just as much or even more.

[01:21:42] And so because we're really looking at this data regularly, I think when Dr. Duran said, what were some of the unintended maybe negatives is that it takes time. And sometimes with these families, you get something in place and then they're gone. And so I think that's part, we're creating individual plans with families and trying to take down every barrier we can.

[01:22:05] But part of that is the time that it takes. We do staff in Virginia Beach, our English language learners with a higher ratio than is expected, but it still doesn't feel like enough. And so we're always looking at that support, but spreading it out for the family.

[01:22:26] Thank you very much, Mrs. Conger. If I could jump in. So, yeah, thank you. So I agree with Dr. Hutchins, and it really did allow us to continue to do a lot of the good work that we're doing. do want to distinguish ourselves from high school versus elementary middle school so at the high school level um you know we the kids have to do more than show growth right they have to pass those SOLs in order to graduate so they need those um they have to do a little bit more than showing growth on WIDA or on that reading test um we have been able to right so for our economically

[01:23:02] disadvantaged we do take advantage of our needs-based staffing so we do have some smaller class sizes we do get to hire all those extra additional staff member that support our students that really make make this a community and have us and really help us support our kids i think dr duran some of our challenges do come from the the students with the limited education or interrupted education uh because they need more time right and though they need more time that should be our goal and sometimes it's a punishment because if they don't finish in that four-year cohort then you know

[01:23:41] where the school is accredited with a different rating so I think those are the challenges that we face here from the school level yeah may I speak please Dr. Carter thank you two minutes left in this segment so you've got plenty of time good deal thank you I'll be quick just I would like to reiterate what's been said previously you know obviously continuous school improvement is the goal and it's altered our focus more at a benchmark level and really from a formative

[01:24:16] assessment level to look at that data to truly drill down and see where our instructional gaps are and the reallocation of our staff in focusing on the deficits that have been identified at the benchmark level has really helped guide our focus as we move through so i do think the identification and the focus on the the subgroups have helped us as a school division at all levels elementary middle and high to adjust and and really to use the word pivot again pivot area instruction uh to target the areas of deficits so again we utilize day-to-days after the completion of

[01:24:53] benchmarks we examine data and drill down at the subgroup level and then alter our instructional staff to help provide remediation to identify and receive additional instruction for those students to alter their educational outcomes and to increase achievement so that's the views from Smith thank you great thank you Dr. Carter so our last question some of you have touched on both components of this question I'm still going to pose it for for others who may have more to

[01:25:26] offer what it's a two-part question what policies and practices have you changed or put in place as a result of the new soa and of course that would include outside of the conversation around the economically disadvantaged and english learners but policies and practices in general and then also have any initiatives been put in place to support chronic absenteeism so for those who have any additional thoughts to add to those two topics i'll pose that now to the group okay i'll i'll

[01:26:04] start so i'll talk a little bit about chronic absence absenteeism um so for us um we have three deans and one um sosa who really is um they're focused on students so every day a student who doesn't come to school we reach out find out what's happening where um you know what how can we do what can we help what's going on so every single day we also this year initiated uh where every teacher is calling so you might get a call from the dean and you might get a call from your teacher just saying you know hey we're checking in just making sure you're okay we keep copious

[01:26:40] notes on that we also do attendance circles so we run restored rj attendance circles at our school and those have worked really well and they're showing really positive trends in our data we have lots of parent outreach and so we reach out to parents we have parent one-on-one parent meetings but we also have informational meetings as well we put attendance plans in place so when a student reaches a certain level of absences we now have an attendance plan in place and there's um it's not a case manager but we assign someone that is important to a mentor in that student's life so it could be one of our teachers it could be one of our counselors and

[01:27:18] that person is really touching base doing a check-in check out with those students we do lots of home visits um and we also do a little bit of a proactive thing at the beginning of the year which we did this year which was we started the phone calls at the beginning just checking in on students to see like hey you know last year um tennis was it was a little bit nicer than this but you know tennis was spotty we want to start the year in a great way uh how can we help you how can we support you do you have all the all the things that you need and just connecting the students right to a person at school um so we're able to do all of those things um as a result too

[01:27:55] of you know just that additional staffing that we've really focused on our for our student support if i could touch upon the attendance real quickly um so what i what we started to do and um so every month i have a meeting with all the principals um and it's called the district leadership team and about three or four teachers from each school and counselors and so on so 130 of us but make a long story short we um there's seven pieces of data uh that we um present each month and one of it is

[01:28:33] related to attendance but we really drill down to the factors that are contributing to children not coming to school and this took some work with the school board also because um our school board policies for disciplines in my judgment and I think the majority of the board eventually in their judgment was very punitive so we saw a lot of correlations between what the research is already telling us kids who are struggling academically kids that were had some

[01:29:09] behavioral issues um and so on were also children that were not coming to school so i i'm and one thing uh i do i've been doing this for i'm not going to say for 22 years but at least the last 15 years of my superintendency um once for one week out of a month i have our student information management department send me by school not by student uh their attendance for a whole week in a row and if i see a pattern that suggests something's not happening right then we have

[01:29:46] conversation so but school board has been great we put some more resources into helping children who are struggling and not coming to school we redesigned what's called the phoenix center for innovative um uh innovation and learning which was initially a program for kids that were just having discipline problems but now it's for children that um just needed more personalized learning um and it has a very high success rate um because we completely rethought about we we

[01:30:26] redesigned our imagination on how these kids could really be and it's been it's been exciting it's good go very very good yeah i was gonna just chime in and uh one i think what's important for us to understand that when you're dealing with chronic absenteeism typically with students there's some other issues that are going on in the home or in their lives so one major thing that we're focused on in acps is having our student support teams which we refer to as ssts and that consists of a teacher a psychologist social worker principal or administrative designee who make sure that we're

[01:31:03] reaching out to find out what is really the root cause to having the students not attend school and we find a number of reasons why kids don't come to school from homelessness to uh you know anxiety to issues that are happening at the home to people who have jobs so they have to contribute to the household i mean the list goes on and on and what we are doing is making sure we're using that data to really provide alternative ways for kids to complete a high school diploma in alexandra city public schools particularly at the high school level um what we're specifically looking at

[01:31:36] is we do have um a blended learning uh program at our high school level where kids uh can take classes online as well as in person and there's a mix but now hey everybody's virtual so we have

resolved that issue but now we've got other problems with that but that's a whole other story um but that was one of the uh alternatives that we were providing our families we also have what what we call an industry advisory board.

[01:32:02] And this is a team of professionals who are a part of the industry or who are in the industry and they're different areas from STEM to business to human services, but we're making sure that we are working with professionals in the industry so that they can give us some insight around what are specific opportunities that kids should have, what are some internships that young people can do that we are giving them opportunities where they're able to get paid so they don't feel like they have to drop out of school to work so you work we'll find the internship for you we'll find ways for

[01:32:38] you to get paid so now we are taking that burden off of you um that is also in the works uh for for us right now but the main key to us really tackling chronic absenteeism is identifying the root cause of why kids are not uh in school and we have to really get away from that whole punitive perspective you know one thing uh that i i used to hear in our school division i don't hear so much thankfully because our culture is shifting um is well we're going to contact parents and we're going to call the police and we're going and that's that's not how we need to operate we need to say okay what is going on with this student what is happening in your household that we may need to

[01:33:15] provide you with support soar or the city of alexandria because their human services um that the city of alexandria also provides so that we can give you what you need so your child can make take it to school where we can find a way for him or her or they to graduate from T.C. Williams High School.

[01:33:31] Great. Thank you, Dr. Hutchins. Before we continue this discussion, we will have a few more minutes to respond to this question. I just want to offer Dr. Duran if he had any questions or final comments. I know you extended your time until 3:30. I just wanted to make sure before you hop off, if you had any comments or questions before you go.

[01:33:48] I just want to thank everyone for being here. It's helpful to hear the different perspectives and I love what I'm hearing. One takeaway, obviously, is the growth measures, the equity focus. which were a major part of the SOA. And so it's good to hear that that's being received and used that way. And in many cases, just validating the work that's already been happening for some of you.

[01:34:07] So that, I really appreciate that. And as you all know, a big concern of mine and passion of mine in this work is how the implications have been for our English learners and making sure that we're raising the bar for them, holding all of us accountable to their success, but doing it in a fair way that really helps make sure that we're not penalizing schools and school divisions that are doing that work.

[01:34:30] And as Ms. Eck said, you know, many of our students need more time and how are we making sure that we're balancing that? So I appreciate that. And it's nice to see many familiar faces on the panel too. Ms. Eck, nice to see you and Dr. Hutchings, superintendent where I live.

[01:34:45] So nice to see all others as well. So appreciate the conversation and you sharing with us your thoughts. Stay engaged with us and let us know how we continue to work through this. And we're here for that. And so thank you very much, Dr. Pexton, for that.

[01:35:02] - Thank you, Dr. Grahn. Appreciate you joining the meeting today. Okay, we'll keep the same table in the question to allow some of our other panelists to offer their thoughts. Dr. Carter, did you have

some thoughts? - Yes, ma'am. Just to tell a little bit about what we're doing in Smith regarding chronic absenteeism.

[01:35:17] Years ago, prior to the implementation of the 2017 SOAs, we were conducting our continuous school improvement evaluation and we to refer back we're conducting a root cause analysis why were we having some some students that continued to fail the sol test so we took our students and we divided them into two groups those that were considered chronically absent and those that were not and when we calculated the total pass rates for sol testing combination we found close to a 20 point differential so we knew that chronic of capsonteism was a was a huge problem for us so we we began conversation working with our board

[01:35:57] and working with uh with our staff and we've developed the program the strive for five program and the goal there is for our youngsters to uh miss five days or less of school throughout the academic year and it's a multi-step program there are a lot of cogs to this wheel and working with with industry within the communities banners strive for five we had a um an art contest to identify a logo that tied along with the strive for five uh we have pledge agreements that our students signed but again to go back to what was discussed earlier there are a ton of barriers there are a lot of different reasons why our youngsters are not coming to school and we knew

[01:36:34] that building relationships we knew that building that connection was was a big piece for us and we also knew that truly to get to that point with our staff and with our community working to develop a trauma responsive community was a big piece of that so we have the strive for five program is one of the overarching goals in smith county to address the chronic absentee is absenteeism but again to address the issues looking at the trauma-informed care building foundational relationships with our youngsters and and trying to find as dr hutching said trying to find that issue what is that root cause why are they not able to come to school and one of the programs

[01:37:13] that we develop through our trauma-informed care is the lens program and it's law enforcement notifying schools is it's an acronym and we do a great job in the commonwealth of acronyms so so there's another one for you the lens program and uh the basis of it is if we have law enforcement that visits a home there's obviously that puts that child in a stressful situation the family in a stressful situation so law enforcement will work through our school resource officer and notify a person at the division office that says hey law enforcement visited Dennis Carter's home last night just to make you aware not that anything about the visit pertains to school necessarily

[01:37:52] but just to give a checkup on that child one to make sure they're in school if not we do a well visit we go and make sure that the child is okay but to provide some additional love love on that child over the next few days make sure that they're okay provide that additional support so when you look at chronic absenteeism um and again i spoke earlier about a concern but there are so many positives that come with that too and truly addressing the needs of the community addressing the needs of the child are our two biggest components that have helped drive again in smith and i'm sure across the commonwealth helping to build those relationships identify those barriers

[01:38:27] through root cause examination and really help those youngsters get back to school great thank Thank you. Thank you, Dr. Carter. That's really impressive. The thought of the impact of our actions or the actions that were taken. The actions taken were to send a law enforcement officer to someone's house because of the challenges they're having. There's a purpose behind that, but then understanding the

implications of that afterwards, that after effect, I think that's very thoughtful and insightful, so it's impressive. So we've entered our kind of go back

[01:39:03] sex time frame here where if you still have some thoughts or comments relative to the question that's on the table that's fine but between now and 3:40ish i'm just going to kind of open the floor to our panelists for any final thoughts final final um ideas that you'd like to share or are things that you'd like the board to consider um for the next seven minutes or so so i'll just open that back up to the panelists real quick i just want to just touch really quickly about some of the things that we're doing here um in virginia beach and one of that is that with that chronic absenteeism before it was just sort of something we knew we needed to keep in

[01:39:42] mind but when the accreditation standards became something that you know included that it became a lot more important and we always knew it was important and we would say our efforts were were were working toward that but putting in safeguards to where when students are marked apps and it automatically generates letters after certain times and it's on my desk and reports that are created to safeguard that but what we have found is that we can create individualized attendance plans for our families and we can have our student response team meetings but there's got to be that follow-through um after the fact and so we're really hitting hard that follow-through with our

[01:40:20] family engagement um specialists that are assigned to certain schools and so their role is to meet with that family and really try to find resources to to help with that follows through one for for example all of our level one through three asl families at my particular school we pair with a family mentor that's bilingual and that and that that mentor is not just for the student that's for the family in their native language so that they can be sure that if they have a question they can ask that person who's then connected with our school and that can't all fall on the school there's just not enough people so we have to reach out into our community and find these

[01:40:59] groups of people in fact our biggest group of bilingual mentors for my school are our local sheriff's deputies um every single one of our um spanish-speaking deputies in our area is is hooked to families to help with that and it kind of brings some um a bit of uh comfort when um they can be a part if we we have permission that if we need to get in touch with that parent then we can reach out to them um but but really providing someone that can can provide that follow through um is what has been key for us i was gonna i just wanted to mention accommodation to the

[01:41:34] virginia department of education and that is the initiative in regards to equity um you know i feel that uh one i want to commend you all for being unapologetic about it i mean we're talking about education for all students regardless of their their circumstances and being that we had this global pandemic where we have seen the federal government provide us in some cases with additional funds in other cases unfunded mandates you know um and you all know all the complications that came along with that i won't get into that uh but we have seen that we can make public education a

[01:42:10] priority in this country and this is our opportunity not to go backwards to how things were. We were not able to serve everybody's needs prior to the global pandemic. So we cannot go back to how things used to be. You know, everybody keeps saying, I want to go back to how it was. No, let's go to a new place, right? This is our opportunity to really reimagine what public education looks like, you know? So let's be proactive. Let's speak up what Virginia is doing. Let's be unapologetic and have the courage and be old and

lead the way for this country. And I just appreciate the fact that I am not only the superintendent of Alexandria City Public Schools, I'm a product of Alexandria

[01:42:48] Public Schools. I was born in Virginia through and through. I was the superintendent of Ohio too, so I got to claim that as well for five years. But for me to be back home and for me to know that our Commonwealth of Virginia is saying equity is a top priority for us, and this is going to be the ticket and the key to equalizing that playing field for our young people and knowing that kids are not going to be exactly where we want them to be, but we are going to do everything that we need to to get them where they need to be so that they can be successful and come back and hopefully

[01:43:24] work for us as educators in our wonderful school system. So I just wanted to give a commendation about that because I have your ear and I get to see you all and commend you for the work that doing thank you for the service uh that you all do um selfless selflessly excuse me not selfishly but selflessly uh that you do on behalf of our young people in the commonwealth virginia so thank you thank you dr hutchins for those comments any other panelists have any final comments

[01:43:56] for the board and i apologize if you can hear my dog licking water behind me okay great well i'd like to now use the next next few minutes just to kind of open the floor up to our committee members and other attendees just to see if we have any questions for our panelists i do dr wilson thank

[01:44:31] you dr pexton and thank you to all of the panelists for being with us this afternoon really great hearing your perspectives and understanding how you are doing the work in your individual divisions but also i suspect you are representative perhaps of what you see going on around you in your geographic areas so i i have a few questions i'm going to start with just one and i want to clarify um to the two questions that talked about supports for economically

[01:45:05] disadvantaged students and students other english learner students how have the supports changed and the second question around policies and practices that you've implemented in response to the soa and particularly chronic absenteeism i think what i heard you all say is that perhaps you have not that that's the revised standards have not required you to specifically do anything

[01:45:41] new and or different but rather you've you've doubled down on activities and practices and policies that you had already started so i heard someone say it gave us permission to do something you know whatever more did i hear that accurately or are there some very specific things that you have had to do additive to in order to ensure that your divisions and or schools are meeting the expectations of the standards yeah so um dr wilson i i use that term permission so

[01:46:16] scott it's great to see you good it's always great to see you let me just you know every community has its own culture so when i was in martinsville and definitely in harrisonburg there was a culture that we want to do everything plus more for every child it was a great place to be a leader if you really embrace the equity and just do whatever you need to do to do it right for all children.

[01:46:44] And I don't want to be critical of the current place I'm working at because it's a great place and I'm very fortunate to be here. But I could only be honest to say that's not as loud as the other places that I worked in, that is this all child agenda. So what I meant by giving permission is for those that may question why is the superintendent and others asking for more resources and supports and redesigning the way we've been doing things for years which no one seemed to complain is if i have to go to that which i hate to do that but every once

[01:47:21] in a while you have to do it i always tell my principals if people if your teachers get mad at you about something blame it on me i mean i mean i don't know what else to say so so i i would say that you know stafford is a growing school system we went i know a lot of the school systems that are on here this this may not seem much to you but uh you know i don't want to get into a number game but when you go from 22 free reduced lunch to seven years ago to 34 there's a boom and when you go from six percent el um in 2014 uh 15 no 14 i'm sorry and now this year will will

[01:48:01] double it to 12 that's that's that's significant for a community um you know again harrisonburg when you were 40 el and martinsville where you were 75 uh free reduced lunch i get all that so um so what i think the standards of accreditation allows us to do is um have a reminder at least annually but that's not good enough and i think what and i've been remarkably impressed with my colleagues on this panel to be truthful i don't know many of them but um there's a couple principles

[01:48:34] there that i'm going to do my best to recruit i'm only kidding but um no he's not he's not kidding i would never do that they already they already have emails in their boxes but um but but i guess what i'm saying is like the accreditation is great start somebody said that earlier but the work is every single day and if we're just waiting for the accreditation report honestly shame on us we should we should be having this conversation doing the right thing with or without the accreditation model that's just that's really what i wanted to spring up thank

[01:49:10] you thank you could i have a follow-on so dr carter particularly i think i heard you say that you um around eds and el's reallocation of staff to meet specific needs was that a reallocate did you find that you had the you had what you needed or you needed to add to the complement in order to me i guess i'm trying to really understand sure you know the the consequences of of what what we've what the accreditation standards have have expected you to do sure and and we instead of using the term

[01:49:46] remediation we first we prefer to use the term acceleration and we feel that has a much more positive connotation to it as opposed to remediation and we have a teams or is what they're called that meet after any type of formative assessment and then we pull our students based on skill deficits and then we reallocate staff to work with remediation so so as far as just reallocation of staff repurposing of staff for remediation or acceleration blocks okay thank you very much dr pexton and panelists again thanks for being with us great thank you any other

[01:50:21] questions or thoughts uh so so one question i will pose to the panelists um you know outside of the scope of the discussion today are there any um components of the standards of accreditation and some of you have made some notes some of you have kind of made it a point to say hey you know this component of it it's still a little bit too complex or this component of it um you know really assessing what's in it is there anything that's not in it in in the standards of

[01:50:57] accreditations uh that that we we need to be considering um differently than we are uh today so i i don't want to halt the conversation but i'm so glad you asked that because there was one thing i told some people in my community i would bring up and i know if dr lane's on this he's aware that of this issue because I've raised it before to him. I just want to let you know that the feedback, at least in our school system, and I have a daughter who teaches in Fairfax and a daughter who teaches in Chesterfield and a wife who teaches in Spotsy. So I'm a family of educators,

[01:51:37] so this comment is not unique to Stafford. But there's an SOA that I understand the state board, i say this with remarkable respect because i do have remarkable respect for all of you that i'm i'm hearing

that you feel very strongly about that you're that you don't want to adjust and i will just say it's the number of hours for core subjects um and the emails that we're getting on parents about uh you know the virtual learning and and to meet the social distancing when we get

[01:52:13] that you do have to adjust your schedule and um and you know there's no relief in that area so we're having synchronous and asynchronous and we're having you know a lot of kids spending a lot of time on a computer and when we get kids back a lot of us have to limit the number of hours to get the number of buses to get the kids on the buses to get to schools so i just ask you to at least have uh maybe another conversation i know i talked a lot of my superintendent colleagues

[01:52:48] um while trying to meet uh you know that hours but i think at what expense to children i rather say these are the proficiencies we hope your children will meet by the end of the school year and not lock it into hours um anyway i i will i i was hesitant to say but i think you gave me an opening I very well did. Thank you. Appreciate you sharing. Any other thoughts?

[01:53:22] Actually, Keisha, do you mind if I ask Dr. Kisner a quick question to follow up on that? Certainly. How are you going to sort of be sure that you're on track to meet the goals if we said it's end of the year only? That is, you know, one of the things that's concerned me is if we just set the target and say here's where you've got to be and don't have checkpoints, you know, if we get through the year and we haven't met the targets we sort of lost the year so what's the thought process on how we do the assessments during the year so that we can change course if we need to for each

[01:53:59] kid yeah so i think it's a very fair question so i think again um our school system like all school systems we have ongoing formative assessments in places we have um you know we just finished uh well not finished but we're in the map testing we're doing our pals testing we have systems in place if kids are not progressing if uh i'd be glad to share with you what we have sent out to every parent staff and student and and the central office being held accountable of student progress

[01:54:34] of progress of monitoring student progress um i'm just feel like right now under the circumstances that we're under um that we have this hour and i would love to know the research behind like why do we think these this amount of hours is getting us to where we need to go i mean look at what we're speaking about this equity issue and all these gaps those hours have been in place for a long time as we're talking about growth and looking at not locking ourselves into a structure

[01:55:14] that's defined by external factors but looking at what are the things that contribute children to to be better learners and i don't know it's a certain amount of hours that make you more proficient i think it's all the things that go into the learning and i do think you could school systems need to monitor progress and there might be children that need many more hours than 560. okay i mean that's time opportunity and effort that's pretty much the three variables to help children be better learners some children could do it in less time some children need more

[01:55:50] time they need opportunities and they need strong teachers but we're kind of treating in this way everybody to the same way and under the current learning models that many school systems are experiencing um either the hybrid the virtual or those have gone back four days even though there's there seems to be potential for relief on the 990 hours it doesn't seem to have any relief from the 560 hours, which is part of the 990 hours.

[01:56:21] So I just think it needs, we just made a major change to add, we were short and I'm talking very specific at Stafford. So we added more time for asynchronous learning and the feedback from our community was like too much.

[01:56:38] This is just too much, and it's too much for the staff. I mean, teachers are working 12, 14 hours a day. And this is just, we're in a crisis. what would what maybe a year from now mr gecko i'll come back to you tell you i was wrong but right now i'm telling you right now everything else is changing i'm not sure why this can't change and a year from now we'll know if the kids really did any better any worse or stayed the same but i could tell you in my community and talking to my kids who are teachers this notion this

[01:57:16] virtual uh and i know the objective is to get everybody back but you know that's gonna that's gonna take time but um i i just feel like we're stressing a lot of people out to meet a a number that is hard to really explain to people except to say it's a number that we're being held accountable for so i may not give you the best answer but that's you know that's my that's my answer from my my experience more about this i know what you're here for but i would dr kisner

[01:57:51] at some point like to talk to you or anybody who's willing to talk about the concept of how we use the formative assessments to be sure this is not going to be just a completely lost year i think we all understand we have you know difficulties and we may not get the same level of educational attainment that we might in a more normal year and I actually have a lot of sympathy for the position that the number may be more arbitrary than not but at the same time I personally am not prepared to wait a full year to determine whether we've missed a lot and there's got to be

[01:58:29] a middle ground where there are some checkpoints along the way to see how we're doing and make adjustments as we go if i could just sorry to interrupt this one yeah one other thing just to say if you maybe you're going to collect this data of how many children are going on homeschool now okay i i think i think we got to look at this in many different lenses so as we're trying to make sure children are being successful i know this as a fact because superintendents are sharing the numbers how many out you know it also the adms that are going down our home school is going up

[01:59:07] significantly and it's because parents are feeling stressed out and teach based on the volume of work because of of this they don't know it's the 560 but we know it's the 560 in the four core subject areas so as we're trying to save a lot of kids which we all agree with i have a i'm i'm a little concerned that we're also losing a lot of kids who have no requirements of number of hours because it's so easy in virginia as you know to become a home school student so i just think it needs

[01:59:43] to be studied a little bit more that's all i'm asking you to please do i agree i mean i agree with you i know this was addressed to dr kisner and so but one of the things i think we should keep in mind is we've never uh written our plan for continuous improvement here with using sol scores because that ship is already sailed by the time that comes around so our plan for continuous improvement is always written with checks all along the way so that we can monitor that and reroute and so our goals that we set forth at least here aren't really based on those end of

[02:00:16] the year uh you know tests but on uh formative assessments and a variety of intermediate measures all along the way so that we are addressing that throughout the year great i was going to say an Really quick, I am going to intervene for just a second because I do not want to disrupt this discussion. I'd like for it to continue at least for a few more minutes. Emily has voluntold either Dr. Lane or President

Gecker to continue facilitating this in my absence just to allow just for some final comments to continue to occur. I do have to hop off in one minute. So please

[02:00:54] continue the discussion. Dr. Lane, would you be willing just to kind of wrap up the call as the discussion continues? I do want to thank the panelists personally, Dr. Kisner, Dr. Carter, Ms. Conger, Ms. Eck, and as well as Dr. Hutchins for joining us today. Your feedback is invaluable. It's always great to get data and facts from the VDOE, and they do such a tremendous job of supplying us with that context. But it's very impactful to get that personal, direct,

[02:01:30] real-world perspective. And so thank you for giving us this time today. So I appreciate you guys joining the call. Please continue the discussion. Several people started coming off of mute during that discussion, more on the table. So I'm just going to leave that there for Dr. Lane to help me manage. Thank you so much. And you guys stay safe.

[02:01:49] I see Dr. Mann wanted to say something. I didn't know if Dr. Mann wanted to say that she was off mute. I was going to say something. I thought you wanted to say something. Yes, I was out of deference for our panel. I was certainly holding back there, but I'll yield the floor to you, Dr. Hutchings, and I will certainly speak following you.

[02:02:12] So I was just, I was going to mention that, you know, what Dr. Kisner said, I agree wholeheartedly. I think in addition to the time piece, we also just need to look at the flexibility and some alternatives. And, you know, as we talk about equity, you know, as we say, that's what we stand for, which I'm commending Virginia for doing, we have to also look at how we can determine the mastery of the standards of learning, depending on the student, you know, like, because some students have different ways of demonstrating their mastery and then allowing us to have just some alternatives to doing that

[02:02:48] I think could be extremely helpful for for school divisions and I think that this is this year was a prime example this past year was a prime example that if we rely solely on SOLs I mean we waived SOL so now we have no data you know the state doesn't now in ACPS we do because we have local assessments that we do and we have ways of doing that but this gives us kind of an experience that if you have kind of just one data source to really determine our progress, we're setting ourselves up for failure, potentially, because no one ever thought a global pandemic would come and

[02:03:26] take over, you know, our lives for the past few months. And it has, and we are now stuck with nothing, you know, in regards to like data to share out from the state level. So I just think that it's important for us to have some alternatives in the future. No, I just wanted to i just wanted to acknowledge dr kisner for his comments you know i have the great pleasure of serving on this board and there are incredible minds and deeply committed to education among you know the colleagues that i serve with um i will say as as a clinician by training with the

[02:04:03] you know a deep respect for the impact of stress and the role that stress plays in the lives of children and adults i think the comments that you articulated dr kisner are really important for us as a board to grapple with um i i think especially when it comes to very young children the reality of of some of the strategies we've had to rely upon to support learning and education virtually and the the level of of of ability for young people to even navigate technology in a way

[02:04:39] that allows them to engage. I take to heart your comments, and I think that this is an experience that none of us ever imagined living, and how do we create a balance with respect to

accountability, but within the frame of what developmentally children are capable of doing through the mediums that we are utilizing to support their learning and certainly the impact that teachers are having to work their way through as they support learning and there are no easy answers here and i don't

[02:05:18] think anybody's looking for a pass but boy i do think we have to struggle a little bit with how do we provide some measure of support and and flexibility as we you know soldier our way through this moment so i i really do appreciate your uh sharing um those comments all right any other comments or uh questions for our panelists the only question that i would raise um on behalf of

[02:05:54] the committee i'm not speaking for my colleagues but i guess i am speaking for my colleagues Is as we continue to think through some of the questions that we've raised here, particularly Mr. Gekker's question about, you know, kind of this formative checkpoints from the board's perspective, Dr. Hutchins, you mentioned that and alluded to that.

[02:06:16] I hope that we, you all will be open to our pinging you back and asking for some thoughts if you have them so that we can be, you know, so we can have that input. certainly we gain information from Dr. Lane and his advisory committee, but also having you all as resources may be helpful as we move forward. I'm sure I speak on behalf of the panel and saying that they'd be more than willing to do that, and thank you all for spending time with us today.

[02:06:46] Other questions for the panel or comments? Dr. Lane, hi, how are you? Nice to see you again. So, you know, earlier Dr. Paxton asked us about, like, what may become things that are missing in the soa and you know i talked about that as being a challenge like some of our english learners do need more time right that's six years six years when they're sliding so i um i'm going to give you an example of what happened to us this year we had two students uh who were 2018 students from

[02:07:20] a cohort 2018. they dropped out in 2018 but due to our relentless efforts from our on-time graduation person who will call you text you you know run after your car uh we back we got them back in school they did graduate this year but uh the school does not get there's no acknowledgement right they were dropped out in 2018 uh they were not enrolled they were dropped out but they came back to us at the beginning of the school year so uh and they graduated um but there's no rec they they don't fall anywhere so just something to think about you know okay uh as we look through

[02:07:55] those SOA accreditation standards and looking to see how do we look at those students with limited or interruption formal education and if they do need more time do we get a six-year cohort versus that four-year model great great suggestion thank you analyst anything else you'd like to share and final remarks all right well um on behalf of Dr. Pexton I will begin to wrap this up I want to thank you all for spending so much time with us today even though I didn't have my camera on I've been

[02:08:32] and listening intently and just really loved the conversation. For the board members, I know there at the end, we took a little bit of a pivot to talk about some of the temporary flexibility, but I think Dr. Kisner's comments have long-term ramifications as well.

[02:08:47] I'm sure you're aware of the 990 hour requirement that schools must complete in a year for totality of instruction, but for many years, the 680 core instruction hour requirement for elementary, and as Dr. Kisner mentioned, the 560 hour requirement for middle school was really not a major flashpoint for school districts because when they're in person, they're well over those numbers.

[02:09:11] If you think about the 560 for middle school as an example, that amounts to about 3.1 hours of instruction a day. It sounds like a lot at 560, and one of the things we really debated as a department when we were looking at flexibility was, you know, what is the basic amount of time that even in this virtual or synchronous or asynchronous environment, your students should be uh expected to be exposed to the curriculum and you know when we started thinking about 3.1 hours a day and maybe a student would read silently for 40 minutes and and then

[02:09:45] they'd be exposed to each of the content areas 45 minutes at a time you know we felt like that was going to be ultimately necessary to ensure that they got exposure to the curriculum uh and we we put we did put flexibility in that uh that you you do have to meet the 560 hours in the way that we created that, but you do it through any totality of synchronous, asynchronous, virtual, or in-person learning. So a lot of the work that students are doing on their own, like I said, silent reading can count towards that 560 hours, and that was a specific flexibility we gave, but we wanted to

[02:10:20] make sure that there was a basic education, even in this pandemic, that we could provide to students. But I think the long-term ramification to think about is, is the 560 or the 680 for elementary the right number. And I think that as we explore this SOA committee, you're looking at more of the long-term SOA and those questions around how we can guarantee quality, how we can guarantee a certain amount of core instructional time, those times should be looked at. In the context of the pandemic, you know, that has, we were very careful when we made waiver decisions not to try to create

[02:10:57] new rules. We wanted, we would do waivers where it was appropriate, but we weren't trying to set new benchmarks that the board had not otherwise opined on. And so I think as we go through this SOA committee, which is really looking at that long term SOA, I think that's a great opportunity for us to look at 560 and 680 for the future.

[02:11:16] And then on the broad notion of the other factors, we heard a lot of great feedback. And I think a question for us to explore is, you know, personally, I'm a proponent of if have to have a federal indicator that chronic absenteeism would be that indicator but if we didn't like chronic absenteeism what indicator would we replace it with because as you learned in the first presentation from dr loving rider those type of indicators are required under federal law so it's it's a complex problem to think through that's why we're so excited to have such a great board and so i just want to wrap by saying a huge thank you to dr carter dr kisner

[02:11:55] Dr. Hutchings uh uh Casey Conger and Maria Eck for being with us today we really appreciate your time and hope that you'll stay close to the phone to be great advisors to us as we move forward and so on behalf of the board and Dr. Pexton we thank you all for your time and Emily I'll turn it over to you for any final logistics thanks Dr. Lane um I don't think we have any other items for the agenda unless a committee member has something they'd like to add um I will note for all of our panelists if there's anything that you feel like you would like to add that wasn't able to be said today or anything you think of later feel free to email me

[02:12:34] directly and I'll be sure to share that with the board as well as dr. Lane and for our board members I think we are adjourned until tomorrow morning at 10 a.m. for our regular business meeting thank you all thanks everybody thank you thank you thank you everyone



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